Door From the Complex of Sultan Qalawun

From the complex of Sultan Qalawun

Fatimid, c. 450 AH / 1058 CE

Wood

W: 74 cm; H: 235 cm

Hall 2

Inv. no. 3553



The front and back façades of the door © NADIM Foundation

This rare surviving example of a Fatimid door probably dates to the middle of the eleventh century. It retains three vertically arranged panels, each showing differing degrees of wear compiled over many years: the lower two, situated at foot and hand level, are markedly more degraded than the upper panel, which was spared much of the direct impact of frequent human use. Although Museum records confirm

the door was recovered during excavations at Sultan Qalawun's complex (683-84 AH / 1284-85 CE) on al-Mu'izz Street, it was not created for the Bahri Mamluk complex itself but was rather part of the wooden fittings of the earlier Fatimid Lesser (Western) Palace (180-81 AH / 795-96 CE, rebuilt 427-87 AH / 1036-94 CE), which once occupied the same area.

The former palace became one of the Mamluk sultans' most favoured building sites as they reclaimed the royal Fatimid city, and many of the palaces' carved wooden fixtures were adapted and repurposed in the succeeding centuries. Removed from their original contexts, these fragments attest both to the artistry of Fatimid woodworkers and to the practical and symbolic importance of reuse in shaping the city's artistic and architectural heritage.



Panels with Horse Heads, Egypt, 11th century. Carved teak, 22.7 x 34.9 cm. The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York (above right); The Museum of Islamic Art, Cairo (below right).

These door panels are particularly significant for shedding light on two notable examples featuring very finely carved addorsed horse heads, also dated to the Fatimid period and now in the collections of the Museum of Islamic Art, Cairo Inv. No. 3391 and the Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York Inv. No. 11.205.2. While often referred to as a pair, the two panels differ slightly in dimensions and design: the MET panel has rounded edges, for instance, whereas the MIA panel is steeply chamfered. Their precise

provenance remains unclear, each being displayed independently and removed from its original architectural context. The partially preserved door in question provides crucial evidence of its intended usage and arrangement: originally, each leaf would have been decorated with a vertical sequence of three panels. Although broadly similar to the MIA and MET examples, subtle variations indicate these various panels were not made for the same door, suggesting the existence of at least two or three sets of doors carved with similar ornamentation, likely intended for display within the former Fatimid palaces of Bayn al-Qasrayn. The ingenuity of Fatimid woodworkers is evident not only in the intricacy of the carving but also in the adaptability of the design, which skilfully accommodates differing architectural contexts while preserving the vitality of the motif.

The panels were originally attached to a larger wooden backing using interlocking joinery, which in turn was integrated into the larger framework of the door. This method allowed the different elements of the door to expand and contract with changes in humidity, minimizing splitting, cracking, or warping. The division of the field into three distinct panels, each affixed to its own backing, represents an early stage in the application of more complex joined and inlaid wooden panels. Comparison with the better-preserved panels at the MIA and MET offers insights into their likely original appearance: a carefully articulated composition of addorsed bridled horses set within an artfully executed intertwined arabesque. Details now obscured by weathering would originally have been more sharply defined, perhaps approaching the chiaroscuro effect achieved in the MIA and MET pieces, a hallmark of the Fatimid style.



The construction of the door itself is equally sophisticated. Each leaf would have pivoted at its outer edge on a wider mullion or stile than that at the inner edge, the extra width being concealed by the recess in which the door was likely hung, a technique devised and used since Ancient Egypt. Horizontal timbers dividing the door into three panels were joined using a clever technique known in Egyptian Arabic as kaʿb meghatti (lit. “hidden heel”), in which two types of joints are carved into a single panel: V-shaped joints on the obverse face and mitered butt joints on the reverse. This solution allowed the door to maintain structural integrity while accommodating both aesthetic and functional requirements, exemplifying the ingenuity of Fatimid carpentry.

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